undermine Chinese defences at its frontiers. In sum, for China the border is not just about 130,000 square kilometres of land. It is about stable control over the 1.2 million square kilometres of the Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR), roughly one-eighth the total land area of China. Any discussion of the India–China conflict over their perimeters is unavoidably, then, one that must include the status of Tibet.

In the late 1950s, the India–China border area became increasingly militarized. Both sides increased their troop presence gradually prior to the war of 1962 and have remained vigilant since then. This was a historic development: over hundreds if not thousands of years, the border was notional and soft rather than demarcated in hard lines. Local people lived in a region without clearly defined boundaries, and pilgrims and traders moved both ways without strict controls, at least until the British tried to tie imperial China down to firm delineations in the nineteenth century. The militarization of the area gives both governments an illusion of control and sovereignty when in fact given the mountain heights, valleys, passes, glaciers, vegetation, and waterways it is almost impossible, even with modern technology, to maintain troops and patrols in the farthest reaches of the borderlands up to India's and China's claim lines. Modern states have a fairly absolutist view of borders, yet in this region they are unable to exert the kind of exclusivist control that they promise their publics. Not surprisingly, India and China are exceedingly sensitive to charges that they have lost control and that the other side may suddenly grab its land.

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In December 1971, days after the Bangladesh war ended, I was on a train to Siliguri and then Bagdogra on my way to Gangtok, Sikkim. As the child of a foreign service officer, I got to see my parents only once a year – the Indian government had decided it could not afford to unite families more often than that. The winter holidays usually saw me packed off to relatives in Delhi and Mumbai, but in 1971, I was sent to Gangtok, where my uncle, the diplomat Katyayani Shankar Bajpai, was the Indian Political Officer (as